

Figure 2.15 *Qala'-yi Chahar Baradar, Ghur Province. © Photograph Warwick Ball, c. 1970s.*

consistency, being principally shallow patterned hollows creating triangle and diamond shapes across much of the surface (Figures 2.13–2.16). Motifs of arches in series were confined toward the tops of structures (Figures 2.16 and 2.23). In some cases, such as the walls of Qala'-yi Chahar Baradar and the stone-footed brick towers at Muna Ala (Figures 2.15 and 2.16) – both within a few kilometers of each other – square or rectangular panels framed tightly wound and molded circular patterns evoking stylized flowers or floral motifs, interlaced with gently curving double lines.[49] The hemispherical arch series toward the top of the Muna Ala tower (Figures 2.16 and 2.23) has additional molded decorations within the arches, possibly derived from a shell or floral design (see below). What appear to be column capitals at the arches' springing were emphasized with a triangular motif in relief. Above the arches more horizontal, frieze-like panels containing thicker circles with smaller central holes, interlaced with the diagonal lines are visible. Again, it may be tempting to consider these decorative motifs as diagnostic of at least a relative chronology in which to place their towers or structures, for example, one "progressing" from simple to complex in order to explain the varying intricacy and variety of decoration. However, any timelines must remain tentative, given the absence of supporting archaeological and epigraphical data.

The method of fashioning the decoration found on many of central–southern Ghur's ruins, as well as its iconography and style (Figures 2.13–2.15), all stand in notable contrast to the known Saljuq and Ghaznavid *minar*s that have been brought up as comparisons (late eleventh–twelfth centuries; cf. also Chapter 1). More significant for our purposes, they diverge